

Countable and uncountable nouns

Learner workbook

Talk about amounts using the right noun pattern.

Understand the distinction

Countable nouns can have singular and plural forms: a chair, two chairs. Uncountable uses describe a mass or general idea: some furniture, some advice. Use a piece of advice or an item of furniture to count units.

Countability belongs to a use, not always to a word forever. Coffee can be a drink in general or a countable serving: two coffees. Use a dictionary to check unfamiliar meanings. Information, advice, and equipment are normally uncountable in general English.

Compare the patterns

COUNT

We need three chairs.

Individual chairs can be counted.

AMOUNT

We need some furniture.

Furniture is normally uncountable.

UNIT

She gave me two pieces of advice.

Pieces provides a countable unit.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose: a useful information / some useful information

2. Count two units of advice.

3. Can two coffees be natural in a cafe?

Use it in your own life

Describe what you need for a new room using a count and an amount.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. some useful information

Information is normally uncountable.

2. two pieces of advice

Use a unit expression rather than advices.

3. Yes. It can mean two servings of coffee.

A word can have a countable use in a particular context.

One possible response

I need two chairs and some furniture for storage.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-21.html